Philosophy · Metaphysics of God

# Religious Language

Student workbook · Ayer, Hick, Flew, Mitchell and Hare

This workbook goes alongside the two lesson presentations: **Religious Language** (logical positivism, its objections and falsification) and **Mitchell and Hare** (Flew's gardener, Mitchell's partisan and Hare's bliks). Work through it one Part at a time. Every task can be completed from the slides and your class notes.

**Name**

**Class / teacher**

IN THIS WORKBOOK


1. The question of religious language — cognitive or non-cognitive?
2. Ayer and logical positivism
3. Four objections to the principle of verification
4. Falsification and Flew's parable of the gardener
5. Mitchell's parable of the partisan
6. Hare and bliks
7. Bringing it together
8. Exam practice — 3, 5 and 12 mark questions
9. Progress check


## How to use this workbook

| Symbol | What it means |
|---|---|
| Short | One or two lines. A definition, a fact or a single step. |
| Medium | Three to six lines. Explain a step and the reason for it. |

| Symbol | What it means |
|---|---|
| Table | Fill in the empty cells. Use short phrases, not full paragraphs. |
| Sort / Order | Put the pieces in the right order or the right group. |
| Exam | Timed, exam-style question. Lined space is provided. |

Key idea Missed a lesson? Every Part starts with a short Recap box. Read it, then go back to the matching slides before you try the tasks.

## Part 01 Cognitive or non-cognitive?

**Recap**

This unit asks whether religious language makes, or attempts to make, objective claims about the world — expressing truths about states of affairs. If so, it is **cognitive**.

Or whether it is not trying to express objective truths, and is instead an expression of attitude or worldview. If so, it is **non-cognitive**.

Task 1 · Table Complete the key terms table.

| Key term | Definition in my own words | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Cognitive | | |
| Non-cognitive | | |
| Meaningful / significant | | |
| Empirical claim | | |

| Key term | Definition in my own words | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Analytic claim | | |
| Principle of verification | | |
| Pseudo-proposition | | |
| Falsifiable | | |
| Blik | | |

Task 2 · Short In one sentence each, how would a cognitivist and a non-cognitivist understand the claim 'God loves us'?

2a Cognitivist:

2b Non-cognitivist:

## Part 02 Ayer and logical positivism

**Key Thesis**

Logical positivism claims that a proposition must pass the **principle of verification** in order to count as cognitive. If it does not, it is non-cognitive — and according to Ayer, non-cognitive propositions are not significant.

**Task 3 · Table** The principle of verification allows only two kinds of cognitive proposition. Complete the table.

| | Empirical claims | Analytic claims |
|---|---|---|
| What are they about? | | |
| How are they verified? | | |
| My own example | | |

> *'If on the other hand, the putative proposition is of such a character that the assumption of its truth, or falsehood is consistent with any assumptions whatsoever concerning the nature of future experiences...it is a mere pseudo-proposition. The sentence expressing it may be emotionally significant to him; but it is not literally significant.'*
>
> — A.J. Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic, 1936 (as quoted in the lesson slides)

**Task 4 · Medium** Read the quotation. Explain the difference between being **emotionally** significant and **literally** significant.

Task 5 · Order Number the steps of Ayer's argument 1–4.

| Order | Statement |
|---|---|
| | 'God exists' is not an empirical proposition. |
| | Therefore, the proposition that 'God exists' is not cognitive. |
| | The principle of verification limits cognitive propositions to those that are either empirical or analytic. |
| | 'God exists' is not an analytic proposition. |

Task 6 · Sort Would Ayer count each statement as **analytic**, **empirical** or **neither** (not significant)? Give a reason.

| Statement | Analytic / empirical / neither | Reason |
|---|---|---|
| God exists. | | |
| God loves humankind. | | |
| Planets move around the sun in an elliptical orbit. | | |
| All bachelors are unmarried men. | | |
| King Harold was killed with an arrow to the eye. | | |

## Part 03 Four objections to verification

Task 7 · Table Summarise each objection, then say whether it supports or threatens Ayer.

| Objection | What it says | Key example | Supports or threatens? |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 History (and morality) | | | |
| 2 The weaker principle | | | |
| 3 Eschatological verification (Hick) | | | |
| 4 Fails its own test | | | |

Task 8 · Medium **Problem 1.** Why does the strong principle make 'King Harold was killed with an arrow to the eye' meaningless? Why is this an absurd result?

> *'would any observations be relevant to the determination of its truth or falsehood?'*
>
> — A.J. Ayer, 1936 — the weaker principle (as quoted in the lesson slides)

Task 9 · Medium **Problem 2.** Explain how the weaker principle rescues the Harold example — and why it lets religion 'in through the back door'.

Task 10 · Medium **Problem 3.** Explain Hick's example of the city at the end of a long desert road. How could this make claims about God meaningful?

Task 11 · Order **Problem 4.** Put the steps of the self-refutation objection in order (1–4).

| Order | Step |
|---|---|
| | So it does not pass its own test of verifiability, and is not significant. |
| | But we are under no obligation to accept this definition, and can adopt other definitions of meaningful. |
| | The principle of verification is not itself an analytic or an empirical claim. |
| | Ayer replies that the principle is a definition — a criterion of meaning — not an empirical hypothesis. |

Task 12 · Short Which objection do you think is most damaging to Ayer? Rank 1–4 and give one reason for your top choice.

## Part 04 Falsification and Flew

**Recap**

A proposition is falsifiable if there is a set of other propositions with which it is inconsistent. For a proposition to have import, it must **logically rule out** certain possibilities.

Example: 'planets move around the sun in an elliptical orbit' rules out 'planets move around the sun in a rectilinear orbit'.

Task 13 · Table For each claim, write one thing it rules out. If you cannot think of anything, write 'nothing?'.

| Claim | What it rules out |
|---|---|
| Planets move around the sun in an elliptical orbit. | |
| It is raining outside. | |
| God loves us. | |
| There is an invisible, intangible gardener. | |

Task 14 · Table The parable of the gardener. Complete the storyboard.

| Stage | What happens in the parable | What it represents in religious belief |
|---|---|---|
| 1 The clearing | | |
| 2 The watch | | |
| 3 Fence, electricity, bloodhounds | | |
| 4 The Believer's reply | | |
| 5 The Sceptic's question | | |

> *'Now it seems to people who are not religious as if there was no conceivable event or series of events the occurrence of which would be admitted by sophisticated religious people to be a sufficient reason for conceding "There wasn't a God after all" or "God does not really love us then".'*
>
> — Anthony Flew (as quoted in the lesson slides)

Task 15 · Medium Explain Flew's conclusion in your own words. What does the Sceptic mean by 'how does … an invisible gardener differ from an imaginary gardener or even from no gardener at all?'

Cognitivist or non-cognitivist?

Flew is a cognitivist: for a claim to be meaningful it must be analytic or falsifiable — and religious claims typically fail this test, so they are meaningless.

Mitchell is also a cognitivist. Hare is a non-cognitivist.

## Part 05 Mitchell's parable of the partisan

Recap

Mitchell agrees with Flew that we should know what would count as evidence against a belief if the belief is to be meaningful. But he claims a belief can remain meaningful even if we do not withdraw it in the light of evidence that counts against it.

Task 16 · Table Map the parable onto religious belief.

| In the parable... | In religious belief... |
|---|---|
| The partisan meets the Stranger, who deeply impresses him. | |
| The partisan is utterly convinced and undertakes to trust him. | |
| The Stranger is sometimes seen helping the resistance. | |
| The Stranger is sometimes seen handing patriots to the occupying power. | |
| The partisan asks for help and does not receive it: 'the Stranger knows best.' | |
| The partisan will not consent to put the Stranger to the test. | |

Task 17 · Sort Mitchell says the belief is a 'significant article of faith' — neither the best hypothesis nor a vacuous proposition. Define each.

| | What it means | Is the partisan's belief this? Why? |
|---|---|---|
| Provisional hypothesis | | |
| Vacuous formula | | |
| Significant article of faith | | |

Task 18 · Medium How does Mitchell **agree** with Flew, and where does he **disagree**? Use the words 'falsification principle' and 'evidence'.

## Part 06 Hare and bliks

> **Recap**
>
> Hare claimed that although beliefs about God were not, strictly speaking, cognitive, they were **meaningful**. All beliefs are made meaningful within a **blik** — a worldview or perspective that affects how we interpret what we see.

Task 19 · Table The parable of the paranoid student.

| Question | My answer |
| --- | --- |
| What does the student believe? | |
| What evidence do his friends offer? | |
| How does he respond to it? | |
| Could any evidence change his mind? | |
| Why does Hare say his belief is still meaningful? | |

> *'He has an insane blik about dons, we have a sane one.'*
>
> — R.M. Hare (as quoted in the lesson slides)

Task 20 · Medium Explain the quotation. Why does the fact that **we** think the student is mad show that his belief means something?

Task 21 · Medium Apply bliks to religion. How might a religious blik shape a believer's values, priorities and behaviour?

## Part 07 Bringing it together

Task 22 · Table Compare the five thinkers.

| Thinker | Test or idea | Is religious language meaningful? | Key example or parable |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ayer | | | |
| Hick | | | |
| Flew | | | |
| Mitchell | | | |
| Hare | | | |

Task 23 · Sort Who said it? Write the thinker next to each idea.

| Thinker | Idea |
|---|---|
| | A claim must rule out certain possibilities to have import. |
| | Some propositions can be verified at a future date, at the end of one's life. |
| | A belief can stay meaningful even if we don't withdraw it in the face of counter-evidence. |
| | Our worldview affects how we interpret what we see. |
| | A proposition is significant only if we know what observations would verify it. |
| | 'Just how does what you call an invisible gardener differ from … no gardener at all?' |

Task 24 · Medium **Your verdict.** Is religious language meaningful? Name the thinker who comes closest to your view, and give one reason.

## Part 08 Exam practice

**How to answer**

**3 marks:** a precise definition, no evaluation.

**5 marks:** a clear explanation with logical links between precisely identified points, and no redundancy.

**12 marks:** explanation (AO1), not evaluation. A precise, detailed account integrated into a clear argument.

### Short exam questions (from the lesson slides)

25 What is logical positivism? [3 marks]

26 Explain the principle of verification. [5 marks]

27 Explain the argument that religious language does not pass the principle of verification. [5 marks]

28 Explain the objection from history to logical positivism. [5 marks]

29 Explain the weaker principle of verification and why it fails to solve the objection. [5 marks]

30 Explain eschatological verification. [5 marks]

31 Explain why the principle of verification does not pass its own test. [5 marks]

## Past paper questions

32 Explain how Ayer's verification principle challenges the status of religious language. [5 marks]

33 Explain Basil Mitchell's view about religious language using his 'Partisan' story. [5 marks]

## Part 08 12 mark question 34

**Explain Flew's view on religious language and explain how Hare responds to this using the notion of a 'blik'.** [12 marks]

Task 34a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

| Paragraph | Key words for my answer |
|---|---|
| 1 Flew's test | Falsification · must rule out possibilities |
| 2 The gardener | Flowers and weeds · watch · fence · bloodhounds |
| 3 Flew's conclusion | Invisible vs imaginary · thousand qualifications |
| 4 Hare: the paranoid student | |
| 5 What a blik is | |
| 6 Back to religious language | Meaningful · shapes lives · insensitive to evidence |

Task 34b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

### Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I gave an accurate account of the gardener (flowers **and** weeds).
- ☐ I explained what Flew concludes about religious language.
- ☐ I linked the paranoid student back to religious language being meaningful.
- ☐ I left out redundant material on Ayer, and I did not evaluate.

## Part 08 12 mark question 35

**Explain Ayer's verification principle and explain the objection that it does not pass its own test.** [12 marks]

Task 35a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

| Paragraph | Key words for my answer |
|---|---|
| 1 Cognitive vs non-cognitive | |
| 2 Two kinds of cognitive claim | |
| 3 Applied to 'God exists' | |
| 4 The self-refutation objection | |
| 5 Ayer's reply: a definition | |
| 6 Why the reply is weak | |

Task 35b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

### Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I explained both analytic and empirical claims.
- ☐ I applied the principle to a religious claim.
- ☐ I explained Ayer's reply and the problem with it.
- ☐ I kept verification and falsification separate.

## Part 08 12 mark question 36

**Explain Flew's falsification challenge and how Mitchell responds using the parable of the partisan.** [12 marks]

Task 36a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

| Paragraph | Key words for my answer |
|---|---|
| 1 Falsification | |
| 2 The gardener and Flew's conclusion | |
| 3 What Mitchell accepts | |
| 4 The partisan story | |
| 5 Links to religious belief | |
| 6 Significant article of faith | |

Task 36b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

### Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I said that Mitchell accepts falsification and is a cognitivist.
- ☐ I showed that the evidence is ambiguous.
- ☐ I linked features of the story to religious belief (Stranger = God, etc.).
- ☐ I did not over-stress faith or trust, and I did not evaluate.

## Part 09 Progress check

Task 37 · Table Rate your confidence now (1 = not yet, 3 = secure). Go back to the matching Part for any 1s.

| I can... | Part | 1 | 2 | 3 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| explain cognitive and non-cognitive | 1 | | | |
| set out Ayer's argument in four steps | 2 | | | |
| explain the four objections to verification | 3 | | | |
| explain falsification and the gardener accurately | 4 | | | |
| link the partisan story to religious belief | 5 | | | |
| explain bliks and why they are meaningful | 6 | | | |
| keep Ayer, Flew, Mitchell and Hare separate | 7 | | | |
| plan a 12 mark answer without evaluation | 8 | | | |

Task 38 · Medium The one thing I still find hardest is... and my plan to fix it is...